



BEFORE

No part of Grant's 1864 grand strategy see [The Wilderness Campaign](#), besides the struggle against Lee in Virginia, was more important than that entrusted to General William T. Sherman.

JOHNSTON OR ATLANTA

Just as Grant would seek to **destroy Lee's Army of Northern Virginia**, or failing that, **take Richmond**, Sherman was to destroy **Joseph E. Johnston's Army of Tennessee**, or failing that, **take the railroad junction of Atlanta**. As the campaign unfolded, the capture of Atlanta became Sherman's principal aim.

A SYMBOLIC PRIZE

Carved out of a pine forest in 1840, **Atlanta** was **a child of the railroads**, four of them intersecting in the city. In the two decades leading up to the war, it had grown into a small bustling city, **second only to Richmond** as a **Southern industrial base**. As Sherman prepared to fight his way there across the intervening **mountains and ridges of northwestern Georgia**, it gained symbolic value, as both North and South pinned their hopes on the **capture or defense of Atlanta**.

From the outset, it was a campaign of maneuver. When Sherman and his 110,000 soldiers marched out of Ringgold, Georgia, on May 7, 1864, he faced a wily adversary in Joseph E. Johnston. With only half Sherman's troop strength, Johnston was a master of the military delaying game. He continually blocked the 80-mile (129-km) road to Atlanta with strong defensive works, inviting Sherman to attack. Sherman preferred to pin Johnston behind those breastworks with his Army of the Cumberland, and outflank him—first in one direction, then in another—with his more nimble Armies of the Tennessee and Ohio.

Defensive strategy

Johnston always anticipated Sherman, withdrawing just far enough to settle into another defensive line. Sherman would again advance, and the deadly game would begin anew. There was, of course, plenty of fighting. Names like Resaca, Cassville, New Hope Church—the bloodiest battle in the region known as the “hell hole”—Pickett's Mill, Dallas, and Kennesaw Mountain, where the impatient Sherman tried a direct assault against Johnston's formidable earthworks, only to be thrown back with heavy losses, would be added to both armies' regimental standards.